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A SURFEIT OF RICHES

The Indian handicrafts sector, in all its inexhaustible variety, has survived many a storm



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Though this essay seeks to list the most significant innovations that have taken place in India's handicrafts sector, it is difficult to paint a scene that is more like a vast ever-flowing river that constantly changes, is diminished or enriched, depending on extraneous events.

The continuing existence of a vast number of India's craft skills and traditions from the times when the Shilpa Shastra was written into the Vedas is a wondrous gift of our civilisation. This takes us millennia back from our day of Independence in 1947. The Chola and Vijayanagara dynasties paid special attention to craftsmanship as part of public expressions of their power. The Mughals infused many fine skills that were integrated into the Indian crafts vocabulary. British colonialism saw to the destruction of all hand skills that came in the way of their forceful industrial thrust. However, they recognised their worth by taking many exquisitely handcrafted objects to magnificent exhibitions in London for showing off as marvels from their territories.

In 1947, when India became free, many prominent freedom fighters—from Mahatma Gandhi to luminaries like Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay and Deen Dayal Upadhyaya—emphasised the importance of rural industries. Marketing institutions like the Central Cottage Industries Emporium and state emporia were set up in the capital, which enabled crafts from the cottage sector to become available to the urban public. Infrastructure and heavy industry were Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru's priorities, and allocations in five-year plans for the craft, handloom and khadi sector, though fairly generous in the beginning, gradually dwindled in comparison to other manufacturing sectors. Nonetheless, even as industrial goods